JONAH

Conversational Version

Jonah's Flight from the LORD

1:1 The LORD told Jonah son of Amittai, **2** *"Go to Nineveh, that big city, and shout against it; I've seen how sinful they are."* **3**But Jonah ran away. **3**He went down to Joppa, found a ship to Tarshish, paid the fare, and boarded.

4The LORD hurled a gale on the sea, and it was about to break up the ship. **5**The sailors were scared, and every man cried out to his god. They threw the cargo overboard to lighten the ship. Jonah had gone below and fallen sound asleep. **6**The captain came and said, *"How come you're sleeping? Get up, call on your god. Maybe he'll be concerned about us enough to keep us from dying."* **7**They said to one another, *"Let's cast lots to find out who caused this catastrophe to hit us."* They cast lots, and it fell on Jonah. **8** *"Tell us, now! Why has this catastrophe fallen on us? What's your job? What's your country? Who are your people?"* **Jon 1:1-8**

9 *"I'm a Hebrew; I fear the LORD God of heaven that made the land and sea."*

10They were really afraid, *"How could you do that?"* (They knew he was running from the LORD; he'd told them.) **11** *"What should we do to you to stop the sea from raging?"* It kept getting worse.

12 *"Throw me into the sea. I know it's my fault this severe storm has come on you."*

13But they rowed hard, trying to get back to shore, but they couldn't. The sea was getting even rougher. **14**So they called on the LORD, *"We earnestly pray, LORD, not to let us die over this man's sin. Don't hold us guilty for* throwing him to *his death. You're doing what you wanted."* **15**They picked Jonah up and threw him overboard, and the sea stopped raging. **16**They feared the LORD greatly and offered sacrifice to him and made vows. **Jon 1:9-16**

Jonah's Prayer

17The LORD had a big fish swallow Jonah, and he was in its stomach three days and nights [Mt 12:40]..

2:1 Jonah prayed to the LORD his God from the fish's stomach,

2 *"I called to you in my distress,*
and you answered me;
I cried out for help from the belly of Sheol,
and you heard me.
3 *You threw me into the deep,*
into the heart of the sea;
the current swirled over me;
your waves and breakers overwhelmed me.

[4]*So I said, 'I've been driven away from you,*
but I'll still look toward your holy Temple.' **Jon 1:17-2:4**

[5]*Water closed in over me;*
the great deep surrounded me;
seaweed wrapped around my head.
[6]*I sank down to the base of the mountains;*
the earth imprisoned me forever,
but you brought me up from the Pit,
LORD my God.
[7]*As my life was fading away,*
I remembered you
and prayed to you in your holy Temple.
[8]*Those who pay respects to pointless idols*
forfeit your *faithfulness,*
[9]*but I'll sacrifice to you with thanksgiving.*
I'll do what I've vowed;
salvation comes from you.'"
[10]Then the LORD had the fish cough Jonah up onto the shore. **Jon 2:5-10**

Jonah Preaches at Nineveh

3[1]The LORD told Jonah again, [2]*"Go to Nineveh, the big city, and deliver what I tell you."*
[3]So he went. It was a big city, a three-days' walk-through. [4]He went through it one day's walk and shouted, *"*God *is going to overthrow Nineveh in 40 days."* [5]The people believed him. They called for a fast and put on burlap from least to greatest.

[6]When the message reached the king of Nineveh, he got off his throne, laid his robe aside, covered himself with burlap, and sat on ashes. [7]He issued a proclamation:

"In Nineveh by decree of the king and his nobles: Don't anybody—animal, herd, or flock—eat anything or drink water. [8]*People and animals have to wear burlap. Call on God earnestly so everyone will turn from sinfulness and violence.*
[9]*Who knows, maybe God will relent from his fierce anger and not destroy us.*

[10]When God saw they'd repented, he relented from doing what he'd threatened. **Jon 3:1-10**

Jonah's Anger over the LORD's Mercy

4[1]That really made Jonah mad. [2]He told the LORD,

"That's exactly what I said back home and why I tried to run away to Tarshish. I knew you're a gracious, merciful God, slow to get angry and full of

enduring love, and relent from bringing catastrophe. **3***So take my life; I'd be better off dead."*

4The LORD asked, *"What right do you have to be mad?"* **Jon 4:1-4**

5Jonah left the city and sat down east of it. He made a lean-to and sat in its shade to see what would happen to the city. **6**The LORD God had a plant grow up to shade him and give him relief. He was glad to see it. **7**But at dawn the next day, God had a worm attack the plant, and it withered. **8**When the sun came up, God had a scorching east wind blow and the sun beat down on Jonah's head till he became faint and begged to die, *"I'd be better off dead."* **Jon 4:5-8**

9Then God asked, *"What right do you have to be mad about a plant?!"*

"I've got reason to be mad enough to die."

10 *"You're concerned about a plant you didn't plant or make grow, that came up overnight and died overnight.* **11***Shouldn't I be concerned about Nineveh, a big city with more than 120,000 people that don't know left from right—as well as lots of animals?"* **Jon 4:9-11**

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